Everyday Application

One core idea from this module I found interesting was the idea of rationality being the sole indicator of human superiority over nonhuman counterparts. Thinkers such as Aristotle and Aquinas emphasized human rationality as a justification for greater moral consideration as opposed to our nonhuman counterparts. Due to our distinct ability to conceptualize , rationalize, and critically think, we are naturally able to understand and synthesize complex moral principles that many nonhuman animals cannot. However, I do not believe that rationality alone determines moral consideration, as substantiated by the article. If we hold this idea that moral consideration is only bestowed upon those with rational capacity, this creates a framework that omits children, those with cognitive limitations, or others that may not possess the same degree of rationality as a traditional adult. We would not argue that these individuals deserve a lesser degree of moral consideration, or omit their sentience due to their lack of rationality. Instead, their sentience remains enough for us to morally consider their suffering. In my opinion, our heightened rationality indebts us to other forms of life that do not share our same cognitive abilities. Because we are able to understand and conceptualize moral considerations, we have a moral obligation to consider their interests and protect them.

This idea applies to my everyday life as I am a pet owner but I also consume animals. I often find it a bit hypocritical of me to be an advocate for animal rights when I am an active contributor to their suffering. I'm still not sure what marks the distinction for me between my two cats and the "factory" animal that was killed for my own benefit. Both are sentient, capable of experiencing pain, and possess an interest in their own well-being, yet I have developed a relationship with one that makes its suffering seem much more morally significant to me. This also makes me question my own morality and details a concept I had learned from a previous module: Intention vs Action. Is it immoral for me to eat meat even if I am not directly the one slaughtering it? If I believe that my heightened rationality creates a moral responsibility towards other life forms, then should this moral responsibility extend to the food i am consuming? I do not believe that we should stop the consumption of "factory animals" all together, but we should be more educated consumers.